

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 1241

By Crowe

A RESOLUTION to celebrate the clearing of Jackson Bridge in the aftermath of Hurricane Helene.

WHEREAS, on September 27, 2024, one of the most catastrophic floods ever to hit this State devastated several areas across East Tennessee due to Hurricane Helene; and

WHEREAS, on that fateful day, the water rose rapidly across East Tennessee as torrential rains fell, causing extensive damage, with vast swaths of communities washed away in the flood waters, and seventeen individuals were confirmed to have lost their lives due to the rampaging water that reached an unprecedented level; and

WHEREAS, located in Washington County, the Jackson Bridge near Conklin is a vital pipeline to the community, and after the devastation from Hurricane Helene, it became a major priority to clear the bridge as soon as possible; and

WHEREAS, just hours after the flooding, area neighbors jumped in to serve, as the community came together to clear Jackson Bridge, showcasing the best of humanity and community strength, as the Lord's hand was made known, and proving that even in challenging times, great things take place; and

WHEREAS, the clearing of Jackson Bridge not only opened a pipeline that allowed for the rescue of stranded people and the distribution of items necessary for the recovery of the area but also established bonds of friendship that will last for generations to come; and

WHEREAS, replacing a ford known as "Wears Rock Ford," named after a Mr. Wear who drowned in the Nolichucky River, Jackson Bridge was first constructed in 1890 and was rebuilt in 1901 and again in 1940, when portions were washed out by flooding; and

WHEREAS, emptying into the Nolichucky River, the Keplinger Branch has provided recreation for the community via swimming and fishing for generations and, in early days,

supplied the power to three mills: Ruble Mill, Graham Mill, and a sawmill; portions of Ruble Mill and Graham Mill are still standing; and

WHEREAS, the current Jackson Bridge over the river was begun in 1987 and completed in February 1988, at which time the old Jackson Bridge was dismantled; and

WHEREAS, it has been said that the human race is at its best when circumstances are at their worst; this adage is proven by the generous and compassionate manner in which the citizens of the community surrounding Jackson Bridge came together during Hurricane Helene; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we join in the celebration of the clearing of Jackson Bridge in Washington County and commend those everyday Tennesseans, who, in a moment of great peril, came to the aid and rescue of their neighbors and friends without hesitation; it is these unsung heroes who comprise the very heart of the Volunteer State.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.